

Life in the mountains

The higher you climb, the colder it gets, especially at night, which makes mountains harsh places to live. They are dangerous, too, because of steep cliffs and crags. Mountains are also often surrounded by lowlands where people live, so animals cannot move from peak to peak to find breeding partners.

SNOWY PEAKS

Temperature drops with elevation, at a rate of about 3.56°F per 1,000 ft (6.5°C for each 1,000 m). As a result, mountains can be divided into distinct zones, each supporting very different plant and animal life. Only the hardiest species survive year-round in the harsh habitat above the tree line (the elevation at which it becomes too cold for trees to grow).



▲ SNOW LEOPARD

Thick fur keeps this stealthy hunter warm, even in the deep snow above the tree line of the Himalayas.



ALPINE HEATH

Different altitudes favor different types of plants. Mount Kenya lies on the equator, and its lower slopes are covered in tropical grassland. Higher up, this gives way to forest, then bamboo scrub. Above this lies alpine heath, where plants like this tree groundsel are adapted to cope with hot days and freezing nights.

FAST FACTS

- The tropical mountain climate has been described as summer every day, and winter every night.
- Some mountain birds, such as the Andean condor, live on the carcasses of animals that have fallen to their deaths.
- The highest parts of mountains are almost completely barren except for a few lichens, insects, and spiders.
- Some high-mountain insects are so specialized for low temperatures that they die if they warm up.